MSc 2024-2026 Master Thesis Process

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Agenda for today

1	The Master Thesis Process
2	Master Thesis: Inputs and deliverables in Term 5
3	Choosing a Master Thesis topic
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The Master Thesis Process at ESMT

- The master thesis is the very final stage of your studies at ESMT.
- It consists of an academic dissertation, thus a scientific work, that an instructor at ESMT guides, assesses and grades.
- The purpose of the thesis is to deepen your knowledge within one research question in a given field of study. This is a task that requires thinking and working individually, and applying your analytical skills to get a deeper understanding for the theoretical or empirical possibilities within a topic of your own choosing.
- You should conduct a critical analysis and synthesis of different sources and use them to make structured and scientific reasoning within ethical norms. You should show understanding, reflection, and intellectual maturity.
- **A great deal of independence is expected for writing the master's thesis**. A supervisor only guarantees you follow a scientific approach. But the supervisor does not tell you what to do, what to write, what not to write, contact you, provide material for you, read excerpts in detail, manage your planning.

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The Master Thesis Process

Overview and timeline

MT Training Phase
Between October 2025 and May 2026 we train you for the task.

MT Writing Phase:
You conduct your research project **independently**

Sept 2024 – March 2025
Term 1 and 2
core courses

April – Sept 2025
Internship

Oct – Dec 2025
Term 3
Electives

Jan – March 2026
Term 4
Electives

April – May 2026
Consulting Project

May – July 29 2026
Master thesis writing

October 2025: List of broad topics for MT proposed by Faculty

Students select their research area by early December (quota per topic)

General introduction to research, with David Ronayne (Jan 2026)

Research methods and academic writing workshop

Research Forum: thesis proposal presentations

June 1st: Deadline for first draft (literature overview, RQ, hypotheses and methodology frame.

July 29: Deadline for final thesis.

August 28: Graduation.

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The MIM Master Thesis Process

The MT training phase at ESMT is a guided process. We support you in several ways:

- We provide topics, including a basic reference list (this is the most important way in which we support you).
- Research strategies week: we introduce you to the basics of research methods specific to your topic (quantitative, qualitative, survey methods, etc). The best way to introduce students to research is by discussing actual papers, their structure, how the ideas came about, what the relevant questions are, etc.
- Three discussion meetings with the adviser/examiner and other students (typically over lunch time):
    - First meeting (early January)
    - Second meeting (mid-Feb)
    - Third meeting (early May)
- Two individualized feedback opportunities:
    - Feedback on the thesis proposal, during the Research Forum, and
    - Feedback on the first draft (actually during the MT *writing phase*).

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Master’s Thesis Process (cont.)

The master thesis can be written individually or by pairs of students.

- Expected length: 30 to 60 pages
- In case of pairs of students, both students will be evaluated independently in the same examination period, via an oral defense.
- The supervisor must agree (i.e. not all topics may qualify for being written by a pair of students)

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Master’s Thesis: Input and deliverables in Term 5

- You will write a master’s thesis on an applied management theory topic.
- You can choose a topic from the list provided by faculty (recommended) or come up with your own topic.
- During Term 5, you will have some preparation sessions for the MT, including:
  - General Introduction to Research (early January, with David Ronayne)
  - How to prepare the research proposal (video tutorial, Guillermo Baquero)
  - Two lunch meetings with coach (mid-January, and mid-February)
- Towards the end of Term 5, you will present your thesis proposal in a Research Forum session (10 minutes presentation, 15 minutes discussion).

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Stage 1: Choosing a Master Thesis topic

EXAMPLE of topic offered by Faculty

- Thesis topic: Survival and Performance of Hedge Funds

- Abstract

  Hedge funds are similar to mutual funds in that they provide actively managed portfolios in publicly traded assets. Unlike mutual funds, however, hedge funds are subject to limited regulation and disclosure requirements, which makes them more flexible in the type of securities they hold and the type of positions they take. The question of whether hedge funds show persistence in their performance receives much attention in the literature. Persistence refers to the notion that future fund performance relates to past performance. Understanding persistence matters as investors tend to allocate their money across funds based on past performance and it is even more relevant in the case of hedge funds since investors are confronted to lock-up periods and restrictions on withdrawals. Pre-requisites: Econometrics and Introduction to Finance.

- References

1. Brown, S.J., W.N. Goetzmann, R.G. Ibbotson and S.A. Ross, 1997. "The J-Shape of Performance Persistence Given Survivorship Bias". *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 79, 167-170.
2. Berk, J., and R. Green, 2004. "Mutual Fund Flows and Performance in Rational Markets," *Journal of Political Economy*, 112, 1269–1295.
3. Jagannathan, R., A. Malakhov and D. Novikov, 2010. "Do Hot Hands Exist Among Hedge Fund Managers? An Empirical Evaluation," *Journal of Finance*, 65, 217-255.

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Stage 1: Choosing a Master Thesis topic (cont.)

A. Students choose one topic from the list offered by Faculty

   i. List of topics will be made available by **end of October, 2025**
   ii. Only a limited number of students can work (independently) on one topic, so it will be first come, first served.
   iii. Students must indicate a ranking of 5 preferred topics (Qualtrics survey, opens on **December 1st , 2025,** at 9am)

B. If student chooses his/her own topic

   i. Provide a thorough justification of the topic (Motivation, relevance, feasibility, a list of key bibliographical references, potential research questions).
   ii. WARNING: this process can be significantly more time consuming, cumbersome and risky (the topic may not be relevant or be less likely to reach a fruitful successful outcome)
   iii. Deadline: **November 19, 2025**
   iv. Subject to approval by the Faculty Lead.

→Students select their topic on **December 1st , 2025**

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Next Steps in Terms 4 and 5 - Timeline

- **End of October:** The Master Thesis Guide will be available.
- **End of October:** Catalogue of Master Thesis topics by ESMT faculty is available, with associated reading list.
  ➔ Look through them, do some reading.

- **19th November:** Deadline for own topics

- **1st December**: Choose your master thesis topic (Link to qualtrics survey will be published on Moodle)
  Topics will be allocated on first-come-first-served basis. So you will have to indicate your ranking of 5 MT topics

- **January 2026 :** Introduction to Research (David Ronayne)
  Tutorial: preparation of research proposal (Guillermo Baquero)
  First lunch meeting with adviser (between Jan 12 and Jan 23)

- **19th Jan - 20th Feb:** Research strategies sessions
- **23rd – 27th Feb:** Second lunch meeting with adviser
- **18th March:** Deadline for thesis proposal submission
- **23rd – 27th March:** Research Forum sessions
- **4th – 15th May:** Third lunch meeting with adviser

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